

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

WEDNESDAY 16 SEPTEMBER 2026



THE AIR OVER THE ISLAND TURNS UNHEALTHY IN EVERY DIRECTION FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE 2019 — AND THE DAY'S TWO LEVERS, A RATE RISE AND A SMOKE LAW, ARE THE ONES THAT CANNOT REACH THE FIRE

THE WORLD

The Muscat accord dies at sea, and the first crack in the oil story is the demand side blinking as the Fed prepares to raise

THE RABBIT HOLE

Metal detecting and mudlarking, all the way down: the coil, the Thames foreshore, and the truth that you mostly dig bottle caps

THE ATELIER

Glassware, from the melt up — lead versus titanium crystal, the pulled stem, and the blind tests that call the varietal glass a bluff

THIS ISSUE • THE WEEKDAY BOOK • NO. 104

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FROM THE DESK

"For every complex problem there is an answer that is clear, simple, and wrong."

H. L. Mencken, *Prejudices: Second Series* (1920)

Mencken's line runs under the whole book this week. Raise the price of money and you cannot reopen a strait; write the world's toughest smoke law and the air still fills; ban the vape and the trade moves to a sedative; lend the unbanked their way into "inclusion" and a pensioner ends up borrowing for rice. Each is the clear, simple lever — and each meets a limit the lever was never built to move. The buy-once desks answer from the far side: the honest fix is rarely the cheap one.

THE STRIP • NEAR TUESDAY'S CLOSE

Brent crude	\$107	▲ +\$10 wk
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,340	▲ record
Bitcoin	\$77,000	▼ risk-off
VWRA (All-World)	\$193.66	▼ 11 Sep held
US 10-year	5.00%	▲ since 2007
DXY (dollar)	~99	▲ 2-wk high
USD/JPY	~155	▲ weak yen
STI	5,639	▼ -1.4%

Levels near the 15 Sep close; USD/SGD ~1.267. The Fed decides Wednesday US time (early Thursday here). Not advice — see p14.

THE WEEKDAY BOOK • HOW TO READ NO. 104

A straight news book this Wednesday, with a thread you can pull if you like. Two levers set the weather by reaching their limit: a Federal Reserve expected to raise rates into an oil shock it cannot price away, and

a haze law that has never once stopped the smoke. The lighter desks work the same seam from the other side — a glass, a watch and a hobby chosen to last — and the Long Read carries it to Ulaanbaatar, where more credit has become a way to buy dinner.

SOURCES 1 Market levels near the 15 Sep close: CNBC, TradingEconomics, Investing.com, Yahoo Finance; USD/SGD via MTFX. 2 "From the Desk": H. L. Mencken, *Prejudices: Second Series* (1920). Issue contents as laid out in this edition.

IRAN & THE GULF · THE DIPLOMACY DIES AT SEA

The Muscat accord collapses with a tanker hit off Oman — and the first crack in the oil story is the demand side

The temporary-transit deal that was to be signed on Monday never was; a commercial vessel was attacked in the strait, one crew member killed. Then, with Brent above a hundred and seven, the IEA and OPEC both cut their forecasts — the bear case arrives before the barrels run out.

The plan was to sign in Muscat. Gulf ministers and Iran had spent a fortnight negotiating a temporary lane through the Strait of Hormuz — a face-saving arrangement to let tankers move while the wider war stayed frozen — and Monday was the day.¹ It did not happen. Hours before the meeting, a commercial vessel was attacked in the strait and a crew member was killed; the talks were “postponed in the interest of consensus,” with no new date, and analysts who had tracked the process now call the accord dead.¹

The backdrop was already grim. Hormuz has been largely shut since late February; the Houthis hold the Yemeni bank of Bab el-Mandeb; and last week a drone strike — Riyadh says launched from Iraqi soil — forced Saudi Arabia to close its East-West Crude Oil Pipeline, the roughly five-million-barrel-a-day line built precisely to move oil to the Red Sea without touching the strait.² With that safety valve shut, the peninsula’s two seaborne oil exits and its main bypass are all constrained at once, and Brent settled the week near a hundred and seven dollars, up about ten on seven sessions.²

And then the first counter-move. Both the International Energy Agency and OPEC trimmed their 2026 demand forecasts on the disruption, with the IEA pointing to demand destruction — China’s Iranian-crude arrivals have fallen to roughly half a million barrels a day from about 1.4 million a year ago.³ J.P. Morgan sees Brent averaging in the high seventies to mid-eighties through year-end; Goldman Sachs has a base case near eighty-five with a sub-seventy downside if the strait reopens early.³ A war that has spilled no barrels is now colliding with a demand curve that is bending the other way.

~\$107

BRENT, UP ABOUT TEN DOLLARS IN A WEEK — A SUPPLY-FEAR PREMIUM THE IEA AND OPEC ARE NOW BETTING AGAINST BY CUTTING DEMAND

TEHRAN

VIA AL JAZEERA

A tanker war, not a blockade. Tehran keeps Hormuz as leverage “until the United States corrects its behaviour” while insisting the waterway serves the region; state framing casts the closure as self-defence against a US-Israel campaign begun in February, not an act of aggression.

ABU DHABI

THE NATIONAL

An economic-cost lens: oil “nears a hundred and eight” as the Saudi shutdown “deepens supply fears,” and the Gulf’s own producers — not distant importers — are the ones now carrying the war’s freight and reputational bill.

THE CHATTER · THE MARKET READ

The sell-side is unusually loud. Citi warns a September rate rise “could deliver a stock-market shock”; retail-facing desks are flashing crash alerts. Read it as sentiment, not a forecast — positioning is fearful, and fearful positioning is what fades hardest when a single gate reopens.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Zero barrels have actually been destroyed; the shut routes have re-routed oil, not sunk it, and Brent “screens rich” against the fundamentals. The falsifier is simple and near: a genuine Hormuz or pipeline reopening collapses the premium within days, and both the IEA and OPEC have now put numbers behind that bet.³

SOURCES 1 Bloomberg (“Iran set to unveil Hormuz agreement”), CNBC/UKMTO vessel-strike reporting, Al Jazeera, 13–15 Sep 2026. 2 CNBC, CNN, FDD on the Saudi East–West pipeline closure, 11–14 Sep 2026. 3 OilPrice (IEA/OPEC demand cuts), J.P. Morgan Research, Goldman Sachs via OilPrice, Sep 2026. 4 Citi via Yahoo Finance; finbold; Motley Fool, 15 Sep 2026 (market sentiment, attributed).

EUROPE · THE OTHER WAR, TESTING THE EDGE

Russia keeps probing NATO airspace — and the alliance is learning how expensive it is to swat a cheap drone

A fresh Romanian breach, the eleventh of its kind, follows the Polish incursion that scrambled allied jets — and exposes a mismatch between million-dollar interceptors and thousand-dollar drones.

The eastern frontier of NATO has become a proving ground for a question the alliance would rather not answer: how do you defend against a weapon that costs a fraction of the missile you fire at it? Romania reported another airspace breach on 13 September, described by its defence ministry as the eleventh incident of its kind, days after Russian drones crossed into Poland in numbers and were brought down by Polish and allied aircraft.¹ Estonia has logged Russian fighter transits near its airspace; overnight, Ukraine said it downed roughly a hundred and twenty-eight of some hundred and forty-nine drones launched at it.¹

The alliance response, branded “Eastern Sentry,” leans on scrambled jets and air defence — effective, and unsustainable at the price. A drone that costs a few thousand dollars can pull an interception that costs a thousand times that; the deterrent works until the arithmetic of it does not.² The strategic point of the incursions may be exactly that test: to map the seams and price the defence, without firing a shot anyone can call an attack.

Europe has begun to answer with money and hardware — talk of a “drone wall” along the eastern flank, faster shoot-down authorisations, and cheaper interceptors purpose-built for the threat — but the standing-up of a continent-scale air-defence network is a multi-year project meeting a nightly problem.² The uncomfortable truth for NATO is that its edge in expensive precision does not translate cleanly to a war of cheap, disposable machines, and the side that adapts its cost base fastest wins the attritional half of this.

~128 / 149

DRONES UKRAINE SAYS IT DOWNED OVERNIGHT — A NIGHTLY LEDGER THAT EUROPE’S OWN BORDERS ARE NOW BEGINNING TO KEEP

THE CHATTER · THE ANALYST READ

European defence circles increasingly frame the incursions as reconnaissance-by-provocation — deliberately ambiguous, calibrated to stay below the Article 5 threshold while forcing the alliance to spend and to reveal its response times.²

THE SCEPTIC

Not every stray drone is a strategy. Some incursions are navigation failures or spillover from strikes on Ukraine, and reading each one as a Kremlin signal risks the escalation it fears. The honest position holds two facts at once: the pattern is real, and any single track may be noise.

ALSO ON THE WIRE

Gaza — neither war nor peace. The ceasefire in force since last October holds but frays: Israel controls an estimated two-thirds of the Strip, Phase 2 of the twenty-point plan has stalled, and intermittent fire has killed several Israeli soldiers since the truce began.³

Ukraine — the refinery front. Long-range strikes on Russian refining capacity continue to shape the oil picture as much as the diplomacy; the energy war and the shooting war are now the same war.³

A weapon that costs a few thousand dollars can pull an interception that costs a thousand times that. The deterrent holds until the cost of it no longer does.

SOURCES 1 Romanian MoD via Euronews; Arms Control Association; Al Jazeera, Aug–Sep 2026 (dates verified against the freshest 13 Sep Romania breach). 2 Euronews; analyst framing, attributed. 3 Al Jazeera; International Crisis Group, 2026.

AIR QUALITY • THE WHOLE ISLAND, AT ONCE

The haze turns unhealthy in every direction — the first islandwide reading since 2019

At dawn on Monday every region crossed into the unhealthy band, Central worst at a hundred and fifty-four. The schools have their purifiers running; the growth forecasters, oddly, chose the same week to raise their call to five per cent.

The dry spell delivered what the forecasters warned it might. Early Monday the twenty-four-hour PSI read unhealthy across all five regions of Singapore — North 104, South 111, East 128, West 128, Central 154 — the first islandwide unhealthy reading since 2019, driven by fires in southern Sumatra and Kalimantan and a longer, harder dry season.¹ The air had first tipped unhealthy this season in early September; it has now generalised.¹

The state's answer is preparation, not prevention. The twenty-eight-agency Haze Task Force, convened in April and chaired by the environment agency, has fitted air purifiers across primary, secondary, junior-college, pre-school and special-education classrooms; the national N95 stockpile is described as sufficient, with distribution to lower-income and vulnerable residents triggered only if the twenty-four-hour PSI passes two hundred.² Grand Prix organisers, four weeks out, have activated their own contingency: real-time air-quality boards trackside, extra first-aid posts, masks for spectators if the reading degrades.²

The other headline pointed the opposite way. The central bank's September survey of professional forecasters raised the 2026 growth call to five per cent, up from three and a half in June, with non-oil exports now seen up seventeen per cent for the year and core inflation easing toward one and nine.³ August's export print lands on Wednesday, after this edition; July ran hot at plus twenty-four per cent, so a sharp deceleration off that base would surprise no one.³

The two headlines are less at odds than they look. The upgraded growth call rides on the same AI-electronics export wave lifting the region, and the survey pencils core inflation easing toward one and

nine per cent even as the haze fouls the air — a reminder that the economy and the environment run on separate clocks.³ The near-term risk to the growth story is external, not local: an oil price above a hundred dollars and a Fed raising into it (p14) are the headwinds a trade-gear, energy-importing economy feels first.

5.0%

THE FORECASTERS' UPGRADED 2026 GROWTH CALL — UP FROM THREE AND A HALF IN JUNE, ON THE AI-ELECTRONICS EXPORT WAVE

154

PEAK REGIONAL 24-HOUR PSI (CENTRAL) ON MONDAY MORNING — THE READING THAT PUSHED EVERY REGION INTO THE UNHEALTHY BAND AT ONCE

THE CHATTER • THE FORUM READ

On HardwareZone the running argument is that the twenty-four-hour PSI lags the hourly spikes — residents report PM2.5 readings well above the headline band in the east and say they “trust the purifier and their nose” over the index. It is a fair complaint about averaging, not about the science.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

The law that was meant to fix this has never worked. The Transboundary Haze Pollution Act of 2014 lets Singapore prosecute firms that cause the smoke; in more than a decade it has produced not one successful prosecution, because the evidence and the jurisdiction sit across a border. Which is why the response is masks and cooling rooms, not writs.⁴

STILL ON THE DESK

Ministerial pay — accepted, with a question left open. The government adopted the independent committee's recommendations on 8 September; the entry-minister benchmark rises toward \$1.8m, phased in, from 15 October. The Workers' Party backed a competitive rise but pressed again for disclosure of ministers' actual total remuneration.⁵

SOURCES 1 Malay Mail, Tempo, Inquirer on the 15 Sep islandwide PSI readings, 2026. 2 Ministry of Sustainability & the Environment; AsiaOne; Grand Prix contingency via Malay Mail/Tempo. 3 MAS September Survey of Professional Forecasters via Yahoo Finance SG; Enterprise Singapore (NODX due 17 Sep); prior July print +24.2%. 4 HardwareZone forums (attributed); Transboundary Haze Pollution Act 2014. 5 PMO; The Star (WP disclosure push), Sep 2026.

BUY IT ONCE · GLASSWARE & STEMWARE

The glass, from the melt up: what you are really paying for when a wine glass costs eighty dollars

Lead versus titanium crystal, a pulled stem versus a joined one, a laser-cut rim you cannot feel — the mechanism is simple. The theatre begins the moment a maker sells you a different glass for every grape.

Start with the melt. Ordinary tumblers are soda-lime glass — cheap, tough, faintly green held to the light. Add lead oxide and you get lead crystal: heavier, softer, higher in refractive index, so it sparkles and rings — and can leach, so you hand-wash and do not store spirits in it.¹ Replace the lead with titanium or zinc oxide and you get lead-free “titanium crystal”: the clarity without the lead, and, in Zwiesel’s Tritan, chip-resistant and dishwasher-safe. That is the modern have-it-both-ways tier, and where a sane buyer starts.¹

Two more tells separate the tiers. A mouth-blown bowl (Zalto, Josephine, Grassl) is thinner and lighter than a machine-pulled one — and more fragile. The stem, drawn from one gob of glass, is seamless; a pressed-and-joined stem has a weld line where bowl meets stem, which is exactly where it snaps.² And the rim: a laser-cut rim is trimmed flush, so thin it “disappears” on the lip, where a rolled rim is beaded and you feel it.² Thinner wall, cut rim, pulled stem: better on the mouth, worse in the dishwasher — and titanium crystal is the compromise that refuses to choose.

Know who makes whom. Riedel owns Spiegelau and Nachtmann; Zwiesel is an independent rival. And the grail has a genealogy — the original Zalto Denk’Art traces to master glassblower Kurt Josef Zalto, who has since left to found Josephinenhütte, so “Josephine” is effectively his newer signature.³ On price per glass: Riedel Vinum, dishwasher-safe, is the forty-year sweet spot near twenty dollars; Gabriel-Glas StandArt about thirty-four; mouth-blown Zalto, Grassl and Josephine sixty to eighty.³

\$20 → \$80

THE HONEST GRADIENT, VINUM TO ZALTO — THE FIRST JUMP IS MEASURABLE; THE SECOND IS FEEL AND FRAGILITY, NOT PROVEN FLAVOUR

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE OBSESSIVES LUST OVER

On Wine Berserkers, side-by-side threads rate the thin mouth-blown trio above Riedel on feel, with several tasters calling Zalto and Gabriel-Glas a wash and Gabriel about half the price. The two standing gripes: the “heartbreak glass” that snaps in the sink, and whether one universal glass beats a varietal set.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE VARIETAL-GLASS BLUFF

Does a Cabernet glass make Cabernet taste better? Shape matters, branding does not. A 2001 *Journal of Wine Research* study found a Riedel bowl raised overall aroma intensity but enhanced no particular attribute; double-blind tests that hide the glass show the effect largely vanishes — it is expectation and the prestige of the glass doing the work. Shape concentrates aroma at the rim; the grape-specific pair at forty dollars each is where the theatre lives.⁵

THE SINGAPORE REALITY · AND THE TUMBLER YOU CANNOT KILL

Where to buy: Tangs and Takashimaya carry Riedel and Zalto; specialists (wineglass.com.sg, Vini Vino) for Denk’Art. In a humid HDB kitchen a mouth-blown grail is a liability — the pragmatic buy-once is Tritan for wine and a **Duralex Picardie** for everything else: tempered, freezer-safe, six dollars a glass, near-unbreakable.⁶ For whisky, a Glencairn at ten to fifteen does what a hundred-dollar tumbler cannot.

NEXT ON THE BENCH · YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Wooden cutting boards & end-grain blocks — end-grain versus edge-grain, the woods that self-heal, and the board you oil for thirty years.

Fountain-pen ink & paper — the two money pits of the writing desk: sheen and shading, and the Tomoe River reformulation schism.

Toothbrushes & oral-care tools — sonic versus oscillating, the head racket, and where the dentist says the money actually matters.

SOURCES 1 WebstaurantStore, GlasswareGuru, Gurasu, Zwiesel/IWA on glass chemistry and Tritan. 2 CMOG (pulled-stem technique); Scientific.Net (laser-rim study); CJF Selections. 3 Harpers, Wine Spectator (Riedel–Spiegelau); Josephinenhütte; riedel.com, mygabrielglas.com, Aldo Sohm (Zalto) prices. 4 Wine Berserkers glassware thread (forum sentiment, attributed). 5 *Journal of Wine Research* (2001) via SeventyFifty Daily; Wine Folly; Fast Company (2015 aroma study). 6 Duralex USA; Tangs; Takashimaya; dram.jp (Glencairn).

SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY · THE PACING SCARE

The AI-chip trade cracks on a “pacing” fear — days after Nvidia agreed to buy Hugging Face outright

A single session wiped the better part of two hundred billion off Nvidia as the debate over how fast the buildout can go spread from memory into logic. The strategic move underneath it: Nvidia buying the open-model town square for thirteen billion.

The market blinked first. On 14 September the AI-chip complex sold off hard on what traders labelled an “AI-pacing” scare — a fresh round of doubt about how quickly the data-centre buildout can actually be absorbed — and it spread past the memory names into logic. Nvidia fell around three per cent, a paper loss cited near a hundred and seventy-seven billion dollars; Broadcom, AMD and Intel fell harder, Intel worst.¹ It is the same risk-off tape driving the ten-year to five per cent (p14): when money gets dearer, the longest-duration bet on Earth — future AI earnings — reprices first.

Underneath the wobble, Nvidia made its most strategic move in a year. On 3 September it agreed to buy Hugging Face — the open-model hub where most of the world’s downloadable weights live — for about 12.9 billion dollars, its second-largest deal ever.² Jensen Huang promised the platform stays open and that “Nvidia compute will not be required.” The promise is the point: owning the town square while swearing not to fence it is how a monopoly buys the map without being seen to buy the territory.²

The selloff and the deal point at the same anxiety from opposite ends. The market fear is that the buildout has run ahead of the revenue that is meant to justify it; the Hugging Face purchase is a hedge against exactly that, planting Nvidia at the layer — open models and the developers who fine-tune them — that will matter whichever hardware wins.² A company confident the boom is bottomless does not spend thirteen billion dollars insuring the flank.

\$12.9bn

NVIDIA’S PRICE FOR HUGGING FACE — ITS SECOND-LARGEST DEAL EVER, AND A BET ON OWNING THE OPEN-MODEL LAYER WHATEVER THE CHIP CYCLE DOES

~\$177bn

NVIDIA’S SINGLE-SESSION PAPER LOSS IN THE 14 SEP PACING SCARE — THE AI TRADE REPRICING ON THE SAME HIGHER-FOR-LONGER TAPE AS THE BOND MARKET

THE CHATTER · THE OPEN-MODEL READ

Usage is consolidating on Chinese open weights. Hugging Face’s own survey names Qwen the most-forked base by a wide margin; Z.ai’s GLM-5.3-Flash reportedly launched as the platform’s biggest single-model debut before its weights even dropped. Both figures are essentially single-sourced — treat them as direction, not gospel.³

THE SCEPTIC

The Council on Foreign Relations argues the Huawei-catches-Nvidia story is overstated: parts of Huawei’s 950-series roadmap underperform its own previous silicon on some metrics, and the whole stack stays constrained by high-bandwidth memory and packaging. Export controls, it concludes, are working — which is a useful corrective to every “China has caught up” headline.⁴

STILL ON THE SHELF

DeepSeek’s China stack. The order for roughly 160,000 Huawei Ascend accelerators for an Inner Mongolia cluster — flagged here at No. 102 — advances rather than re-explains: domestic chipmakers now get early access to the next model, and Nvidia stays locked out of that pipeline.⁴

SOURCES 1 24/7 Wall St., Tradingpedia, GuruFocus on the 14 Sep chip selloff (percentages via search index — direction corroborated across three outlets). 2 CNBC, TechCrunch, CNN on Nvidia–Hugging Face, 3 Sep 2026. 3 Hugging Face State of Open Models; OpenRouter launch figures (single-sourced, attributed). 4 Council on Foreign Relations, “China’s AI Chip Deficit”; DeepSeek/Huawei reporting, 2026.

THE HOME LAB • THE MEMORY BILL

A DDR5 kit now costs what a used graphics card did last year — and the local-model pick shifts again

The squeeze that started as an advisory is now the dominant fact of building a rig at home: makers are pouring capacity into datacentre memory and starving the consumer channel.

The number that matters is not a benchmark this month; it is a price. A German retail index has DDR5 running near five times its mid-2025 baseline; a 32-gigabyte kit that cost roughly eighty dollars last year is quoted around four hundred and thirty, a 64-gigabyte kit near eleven hundred, as Samsung, SK Hynix and Micron keep shifting wafers to the high-bandwidth memory that AI datacentres inhale.¹ Forecasters see the squeeze running through the rest of 2026 and into 2027. The standing verdict — buy the memory now — only firms.¹

On what to actually run: for a single high-end card in the 32-gigabyte class, the buying-guide consensus is a quantised mixture-of-experts model that fits in memory — a GLM Air variant as the daily driver, a Qwen coder for programming; a two-card, 64-gigabyte rig opens the newer GLM-Flash and multimodal Qwen weights.² Read those as buying-guide consensus, not a verified bench — the honest home-lab position is that a 32-gigabyte card runs compressed thirty-to-hundred-billion-parameter models well, and frontier weights not at all.²

The strategic read for a buy-once builder is to invert the usual order. In a normal cycle the graphics card is the scarce, appreciating asset and memory is the cheap afterthought; this cycle has flipped it, and system RAM and VRAM-adjacent kit are the parts whose price is running away.¹ The weights that run on them are free, open and improving weekly — a GLM here, a Qwen there — so the durable move is to

over-spec the memory now and let the models catch up to it, rather than wait for a “better” card into a market where the bottleneck has moved to the DIMM slot.²

THE BENCH, THIS WEEK

Top open weight: on the Artificial Analysis intelligence index, the strongest open model this month is a GLM variant, ahead of Kimi and Qwen — but a separate ranking puts a Qwen Max first, so do not conflate the two boards.²

The floor keeps rising: DDR4 spot has hit record levels too, and forecasters see no relief before 2027–28 as makers keep the fabs pointed at datacentre memory.¹

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DDR5 RETAIL PRICES VERSUS A MID-2025 BASELINE — THE AI DATACENTRE’S MEMORY APPETITE, ARRIVING AS A LINE ITEM ON YOUR BUILD

THE CHATTER • THE BUILDER READ

The forums have flipped from “which model” to “which RAM, and when.” The rational move for a buy-once builder is to spec memory to the ceiling now and let the model landscape catch up — because the weights are free and improving, and the silicon to feed them is neither.

THE SCEPTIC

The “buy RAM now” drumbeat is itself a small bubble signal. Some trackers think consumer DDR5 is near a local peak even as datacentre demand persists, and a 32-gigabyte card still caps you at Q4 of a mid-size model — you are not running the frontier at home, whatever the memory costs. Panic-buying a component is how you overpay at the top.¹

GEAR WE'RE WATCHING · HEADPHONES AS A SYSTEM NODE

Sonos puts a whole system on your head — and asks you to trust the app one more time

The Ace Ultra adds a new forty-millimetre driver, thirty-five hours of battery and, the real differentiator, a direct Wi-Fi link into a Sonos home — four hundred and forty-nine dollars, general sale on the twenty-ninth.

Sonos announced the Ace Ultra on 1 September, with pre-orders open and general availability on 29 September — so the review wave is landing now, in the decision window.¹ The headline is not the sound, though the driver is new and the adaptive noise cancellation runs off ten microphones; it is that the Ace Ultra behaves like a node on your Sonos system, connecting over Wi-Fi rather than only Bluetooth, with headphone-to-headphone linking. For an owner already inside the Sonos world, that is the pitch: the headphones finally act like Sonos, not like an accessory that happens to carry the name.¹

At four hundred and forty-nine dollars it sits with the premium over-ears — up to about thirty-five hours with cancellation on, four finishes, a Beam Ultra soundbar launched alongside it.¹ Singapore pricing was not confirmed at press time. For the buy-once buyer the question is whether the Sonos-node trick is worth the ecosystem lock, because a pair of headphones that behaves like a speaker only pays off if you have the speakers.²

Against the field — the Bose and Sony flagships this reader would cross-shop — the Ace Ultra's case is not that it cancels noise better but that it collapses two devices into one for a Sonos household: the same pair that silences a plane becomes a private channel of the living-room system at home.¹ Outside that ecosystem, the pitch is ordinary premium headphones at a premium price, and the older, cheaper competition is very good.²

~35 hrs

BATTERY WITH CANCELLATION ON — THE SPEC THAT MATTERS MORE THAN THE DRIVER FOR A LONG-HAUL FLYER

US\$449

THE ACE ULTRA'S LAUNCH PRICE — PREMIUM-TIER MONEY FOR A SET WHOSE REAL TRICK IS WI-FI MEMBERSHIP OF A SONOS HOME

THE CHATTER · THE OWNER READ

Early hands-on calls it “smarter than expected.” A caution on the community read: most of the retrievable Reddit discussion is about the Arc and Beam soundbars, not these headphones — the owner base is days old — so treat soundbar sentiment as no guide to the Ace Ultra. This is a first-look verdict, not an owner verdict.²

THE SCEPTIC

Four hundred and forty-nine dollars, and still no lossless spatial standard at launch; the differentiator is Wi-Fi linking and up-firing drivers, and the ask is that you trust the Sonos app again after its well-documented 2024 meltdown broke basic playback for months. Buy it for the system integration, not on faith the software is fixed.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

The one-year-watch case, revisited. Last issue's Ultra 4 argument holds here too: a device replaced every year is a consumable, not a buy-once. The Ace Ultra earns its keep only if it stays on your head for five years — which, for headphones, is the reasonable bet.

SOURCES 1 Bloomberg (“Sonos debuts \$449 Ace Ultra”), Engadget hands-on, 9to5Mac, Sonos newsroom, 1 Sep 2026. 2 Into the HiFi (sceptic); Engadget (first-look); r/sonos (attributed, soundbar-weighted — flagged).

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · THE DIAL THAT LOST ITS CLUTTER

Orient Star drops the power-reserve hand it has carried since 1996 — and lets the dial breathe

For its seventy-fifth anniversary the Sakigake Three Hand strips the date and the power-reserve indicator for a clean, symmetrical face and a new in-house movement. Around eight hundred and eighty euros. You are paying for the look, not the chronometry.

“Sakigake” means forerunner, and the point of the watch is subtraction. It is the first Orient Star Contemporary piece since 1996 to drop the brand’s signature power-reserve indicator — and the date window with it — leaving a stripped, symmetrical dial in a 38.7-millimetre steel case.¹ Under it sits a new in-house automatic, the calibre F7542, with over fifty hours of reserve and a sapphire display back.¹ Reviewers have been warm: Gear Patrol clocked “heavy Rolex vibes” in the clean Oyster-Perpetual-style dial; Fratello read it as a genuine new design direction that stays unmistakably Orient Star.²

The lineup runs four regular dials plus a 900-piece copper-tone limited edition; regular models are about eight hundred and eighty euros, the limited around nine hundred and sixty — local Singapore pricing unconfirmed, though the brand usually lands well under the grey-market estimate.² This is the buy-once reader’s kind of watch precisely because it is honest about what it is not.³

Where it sits in the case matters. This is not a Grand Seiko rival on finishing, nor a Swiss chronometer on rate; it is a clean, in-house automatic at a price where most rivals still fit a bought-in movement. For a reader who already owns the serious pieces, the Sakigake is the honest everyday watch — the one you wear without thinking, whose value is the design and the view through the back, not a number on a timing machine.² The copper-tone limited edition, at 900 pieces, is the one collectors will chase.¹

~€880

THE REGULAR SAKIGAKE THREE HAND — AN IN-HOUSE AUTOMATIC AT A PRICE WHERE THE COMPETITION STILL BUYS ITS MOVEMENTS IN

+15 / -5

SECONDS PER DAY, THE F7542’S STATED ACCURACY — LOOSER THAN A COSC CHRONOMETER’S -4/+6; THE PRICE IS FINISHING AND DESIGN, NOT THE BEAT

THE CHATTER · THE COLLECTOR READ

The enthusiast press frames it as the watch that could win over people who never connected with Orient Star’s traditional styling — a “stripped down and it works” consensus. The recurring note: at this price, an in-house movement you can watch through the caseback is the real value, not the accuracy figure.²

THE SCEPTIC

“Rolex vibes” is styling, not horology. The F7542’s tolerance is wider than a chronometer’s and much wider than a Rolex Superlative’s -2/+2; you are paying for the case finishing, the display back and a clean face, not for keeping better time. Which is fine — as long as the marketing does not persuade you it is a Rolex at a tenth of the money.³

The point of the watch is subtraction — the first Contemporary Orient Star since 1996 to take the power-reserve hand off the dial and let it breathe.

SOURCES 1 Fratello Watches; MasterHorologer; Orient Star press materials, 10 Sep 2026. 2 Gear Patrol; Luxe Digital; Two Broke Watch Snobs (reviewer sentiment). 3 Movement-tolerance comparison (COSC / Rolex Superlative), maker specifications.

CULTURE DESK · THE WIDEST SPLIT OF THE YEAR

A witch sequel opens number one with a thirty-six from the critics and a ninety-plus from the fans

“Practical Magic 2” reunited its stars, topped the weekend, and split the room down the middle — a case study in who actually buys a ticket in 2026.

The gap is the whole point. “Practical Magic 2,” the long-delayed sequel with Sandra Bullock and Nicole Kidman, opened at number one over the weekend of 11–13 September; the exact domestic gross is single-sourced and worth holding lightly, but the split is corroborated: thirty-six per cent on the critics’ Tomatometer against a verified audience score in the low nineties.¹ Critics called it a hundred-and-thirty-minute nostalgia cash-in; the fans turned out for the reunion regardless. When the reviews and the box office disagree this loudly, the audience score is a turnout signal, not a quality verdict.¹

The week’s other culture headline had already been handed out. The 78th Primetime Emmys, covered here last issue, produced a record of its own: Matthew Rhys became the first performer to win lead-acting Emmys across all three genres, and “Widow’s Bay” took six.² On the music side, a heavy 11 September release day brought new records from Bloc Party and Bonobo among others — too early for first-week numbers, so we hold them.²

The split matters beyond one film. A number-one opening on a thirty-six per cent critics’ score is a working definition of the franchise-fan economy: the box office is increasingly decided by pre-committed audiences buying a feeling — a reunion, a mood, a sequel to something they loved — rather than by reviews, which now function more as a signal to the undecided than a verdict the base consults.¹ The studios have read the same data, which is why the

autumn slate leans on legacy titles with a built-in audience rather than on originals a critic might champion.

#1

THE WEEKEND’S DOMESTIC OPENING — PROOF THAT AFFECTION FOR A TWENTY-SEVEN-YEAR-OLD ORIGINAL OUTSELLS A FRESH SET OF REVIEWS

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Emmys, banked. Last issue’s desk carried the 78th Primetime results; the record that stuck is Matthew Rhys’s lead-acting sweep across all three genres — the kind of career milestone the ceremony exists to produce.²

36 vs ~93

CRITICS’ VERSUS AUDIENCE SCORE FOR THE WEEKEND’S NUMBER ONE — THE YEAR’S STARKEST DIVIDE, AND A PORTRAIT OF THE FRANCHISE-FAN ECONOMY

THE CHATTER · THE AUDIENCE READ

The fan defence is that the critics reviewed a different film than the one the audience bought a ticket to see — comfort, reunion, a specific autumn mood. It is a real phenomenon and a real trap: a high audience score on a nostalgia property tells you the base showed up, not that the film is good.¹

THE SCEPTIC

Both numbers can mislead. Opening-weekend audience scores skew to the people who most wanted to like it; the thirty-six from critics is a firmer signal of the film itself. Treat the ninety-plus as a measure of affection for the first film, banked twenty-seven years ago, more than a verdict on this one.

SOURCES 1 film-book (opening gross, single-sourced — flagged); Forbes, CBR, Rotten Tomatoes (RT scores corroborated), 11–13 Sep 2026. 2 CNN, NBC, Television Academy (78th Emmys results); Exclaim!, 11 Sep 2026 (music releases, reception held).

RAISING THEM WELL · THE SECONDARY-1 CONVERSATION

The drug-laced vape, not the nicotine one, is the talk to have before Secondary 1

Etomidate “Kpods” are a sedative in a vape shell, and Singapore has spent the year moving them from the poisons list to the drug list. The numbers are real, the panic is optional — and, new this month, there is finally a treatment door beside the enforcement one. General guidance, not medical advice.

A twelve-year-old starting secondary school this year is walking into a landscape that changed fast. “Kpods” — vapes laced with etomidate, an anaesthetic — are the reason. Singapore reclassified etomidate as a Class C controlled drug under the Misuse of Drugs Act from 1 September 2025, moving it off the Poisons Act; supplying or trafficking now carries up to twenty years’ jail and caning.¹ The renamed Tobacco and Vaporisers Control Act took effect on 1 May 2026, and individual vape fines rose to as much as ten thousand dollars.¹

The scale is documented, not rumoured. In the first quarter of 2026, over 2,500 people were caught vaping — 377 of those cases involving etomidate — and 206 students were referred to the health authority by their schools; the second quarter ran to 2,428 cases, 457 of them etomidate, with 245 students referred.² Etomidate-vape cases have climbed from fewer than fifty a year before 2020 to more than three thousand recently.² A Singapore Medical Journal case series found youths made up the bulk of cases and noted children as young as twelve experimenting.³

The clinical picture is why this is not ordinary vaping. Clinicians describe an unsteady, “zombie-like” gait, emotional dysregulation, vomiting, muscle spasms, seizures and, with chronic overdose, the risk of irreversible brain damage; users report dependence forming within months.³ The conversation to have

with a Secondary-1 child is specific: a Kpod is not a nicotine vape, it is a sedative drug in the same shell — and the tell-tale signs are physical, not just the smell.

It helps to know what etomidate actually is. In a hospital it is an anaesthetic used to induce unconsciousness for a procedure — a serious drug with a narrow safe dose, never designed to be inhaled unmetered from a vape.³ That is why the “Kpod” is dangerous in a way a nicotine vape is not: the user has no idea how much sedative they are taking, and the same puff that produces a mild high one day can, at a slightly higher concentration, drop them.³ The shift from the Poisons Act to the drug list was the state formally recognising that this is no longer a smoking problem.¹

3,000+

ETOMIDATE-VAPE CASES A YEAR NOW, UP FROM FEWER THAN FIFTY BEFORE 2020 — THE CURVE THAT MOVED A NICOTINE PROBLEM ONTO THE DRUG LIST

245

STUDENTS REFERRED TO THE HEALTH AUTHORITY FOR VAPING IN Q2 2026 ALONE — REAL AND RISING, AGAINST A SCHOOL POPULATION IN THE HUNDREDS OF THOUSANDS

A Kpod is not a nicotine vape. It is a sedative drug in the same shell — and the tell-tale signs are physical, not just the smell.

SOURCES 1 Central Narcotics Bureau (etomidate reclassification, 1 Sep 2025); Malay Mail (Tobacco and Vaporisers Control Act, 1 May 2026). 2 HSA (Q1 2026); MOH (Q2 2026); Mothership; Stomp. 3 *Singapore Medical Journal* case series (ketamine/etomidate in vaping devices), 2025–26. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE TWEEN YEARS · ENFORCEMENT, AND THE DOOR BESIDE IT

Singapore just opened a treatment route — and the honest debate is whether the crackdown helps or hardens

From this month a struggling teen can be treated, not only punished. That matters, because the enforcement-only approach has parents worried the schools are becoming checkpoints.

The newest development is the one to hold onto. From 1 September 2026, people seeking help for etomidate abuse can approach the Institute of Mental Health, with services subsidised for referred citizens and residents — the first formal treatment pathway rather than a purely punitive one.¹ It sits beside a hard enforcement regime: more than 260 schools have been issued test kits, some using metal detectors, and repeat offenders face suspension and, for boys, caning.²

Which raises the real argument, and it is not settled. After the tougher school rules rolled out, parents and students told reporters they feel campuses are being turned into “high-security zones rather than places of learning,” and warned that determined teens will find workarounds.² The grief is real too: coverage of a father who turned his son’s death into an anti-Kpod campaign has circulated widely among Singapore parents. The mood is anxious and mobilised at once.²

For a parent, the practical shape of it is simple enough. The conversation is not the generic “don’t vape” talk; it is specific to a drug that produces an unsteady gait and sudden emotional swings, and it is worth having before the child changes schools, when the peer group and the commute both widen.³ The second point is quieter and newer: a child who has already experimented is no longer only a disciplinary problem but, from this month, someone who can be referred for treatment — which changes what a worried parent can actually do with the knowledge.¹

WHAT CHANGED THIS YEAR

Sep 2025: etomidate moved to the Misuse of Drugs Act — trafficking now carries jail and caning.¹

May 2026: the Tobacco and Vapourisers Control Act takes effect; vape fines rise to as much as ten thousand dollars.¹

Sep 2026: a treatment pathway opens at the Institute of Mental Health — help, not only punishment.¹

260+

SCHOOLS ISSUED VAPING TEST KITS — THE ENFORCEMENT SIDE OF A RESPONSE THAT, FROM THIS MONTH, FINALLY HAS A TREATMENT SIDE TOO

There is a wider lesson in the sequence, and it is the issue’s thread in miniature. Singapore reached first for the clear, simple lever — reclassify, fine, detect, cane — and found, as Australia found with its social-media ban, that a determined teenager routes around a wall. The treatment door added this month is the quieter admission that enforcement alone was the wrong shape of answer, and that a child caught is a child to be helped as well as punished.¹

THE CHATTER · THE PARENT READ

On parenting forums the Secondary-1 handover thread is busy: how to talk about Kpods without either terrifying a child or waving it away. The consensus that holds up: have the specific conversation before the transition, not after, and know that a struggling child can now be referred for help rather than only disciplined.²

THE SCEPTIC · DON’T BE ALARMIST

Keep the denominator in view. A couple of hundred student referrals a quarter is real and rising — and still a small share of a student population in the hundreds of thousands. The vivid clinical picture rests partly on a twenty-two-case series, which is a signal, not a prevalence estimate; do not extrapolate its severity to the average child. The live question is whether detection and caning, or treatment and harm-reduction, does more good.³

THE BIG PICTURE · THE HIKE INTO THE SHOCK

A rate rise the Fed does not want, into an oil shock it cannot fix

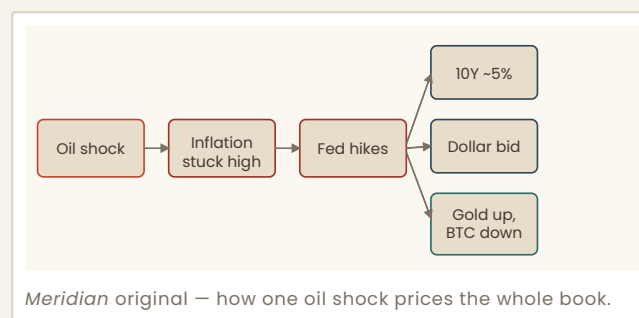
The market prices a nine-in-ten chance of the first US hike since 2023 when the decision lands early Thursday here. The ten-year has touched five per cent; gold makes records; bitcoin, tellingly, does not. Market explanation, not investment advice.

The causal chain is unusually clean this week, and it runs the wrong way for almost everything. A Middle East supply shock — Hormuz constrained since February, Bab el-Mandeb closed, the Saudi bypass pipeline shut (p3) — has pushed Brent near a hundred and seven and lodged US inflation well above target.¹ That has forced the Federal Reserve toward a rate rise it plainly does not want: futures price roughly a nine-in-ten chance of a quarter-point hike to 3.75–4.00 per cent, the first increase since 2023, when the decision is announced Wednesday afternoon in Washington — early Thursday in Singapore, after this edition.¹ Chair Kevin Warsh has said underlying inflation has not meaningfully improved. Hold the outcome as pending; the pricing is what we can print.

The regime is risk-off, dollar-bid, and higher-for-longer flipping to higher-again — an oil-driven stagflationary impulse forcing a hawkish bank rather than a booming one easing. The ten-year Treasury yield touched five per cent, its highest since 2007 and a fifth straight session up; the dollar sits at a two-week high; the Straits Times Index fell about one and a half per cent to close near 5,639, a third down session.² And the sharpest tell is in the two stores of value: gold is at record highs around 4,340 dollars, while bitcoin has fallen toward 77,000. Same tape, opposite behaviour — this cycle, gold is the haven and bitcoin is a risk asset.²

The read-through to a Singapore portfolio is direct. The Straits Times Index has given back its record and the local dollar has softened toward 1.267 to the greenback, both of them the domestic face of a global dollar bid; global bonds, the supposed ballast, are falling in price as yields climb, so the diversification a balanced portfolio counts on is

doing the opposite of its job.² An all-world equity holding faces a higher discount rate and a slower growth path at once — the specific unpleasantness of a supply-shock hike, where the thing raising rates is also the thing slowing the economy.¹



5.00%

THE US 10-YEAR, ITS HIGHEST SINCE 2007 — THE NUMBER EVERY OTHER ASSET NOW DISCOUNTS AGAINST

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

A forced hike into an oil shock is a headwind for both sides of a global portfolio at once: all-world equity (VWRA) faces higher discount rates and slowing growth, and global bonds are pressured as yields climb — the diversification that is supposed to help is hurting. Gold is the cycle's haven; bitcoin is trading with equities, not against them. Regime tags: risk-off, dollar-bid, higher-again.

THE SCEPTIC

The hike may be the top of the fear, not the start of a spiral. Analyst oil targets (JPM high-seventies to mid-eighties, Goldman ~85 with sub-70 downside) are forecasts, flagged as forecasts — and if the strait reopens, the inflation impulse fades and the whole hawkish chain unwinds. Do not confuse a supply-shock hike with a demand-boom one; they end very differently.³

SOURCES 1 CME FedWatch; Yahoo Finance; Chase; Robinhood event page (FOMC 15–16 Sep 2026, decision 16 Sep 2pm ET). 2 TradingEconomics (10Y, DXY); iTiger/Yahoo (STI close 15 Sep); Coinbase/Robinhood (gold, BTC). 3 J.P. Morgan Research; Goldman Sachs via OilPrice (forecasts). Market explanation, not investment advice.

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE · METAL DETECTING & MUDLARKING

History you can hold: the coil, the foreshore, and the jolt of the first hammered coin

One is swinging an electromagnetic coil over a field; the other is reading a tidal riverbank at low water. Both promise the same thing – a thing no one has touched for centuries – and both are governed by a surprising amount of law.

The gateway moment is always the same: the first old coin. A signal turns out to be a Victorian penny, or, in the dream version, a hand-struck medieval “hammered” silver, and the jolt of touching something two hundred years down does the rest. Metal detecting is coil-over-ground – fields, parks, beaches, woods – for coins, buttons, relics and the occasional hoard. Mudlarking is its low-tech, archaeology-adjacent cousin: searching the tidal foreshore of a river, above all London’s Thames, for what the water gives back – clay pipes, Tudor pins, Roman pottery, medieval coins – mostly by eye at low tide, not by digging.¹

The world is bigger than the hobby’s quiet image suggests. The main subreddit runs to roughly 348,000 members; the mudlarking sub, created in 2018, to about 39,000.² In Britain the numbers carry real weight: detectorists and mudlarks contribute more than ninety-five per cent of all archaeological finds recorded each year, and Thames mudlarks alone log over seven hundred finds a year in the City of London.² Two cultural jolts widened the door – the BBC’s *Detectorists*, credited with a surge that pushed recorded treasure finds past eleven hundred in 2016, and Lara Maiklem’s 2019 bestseller *Mudlarking*, which turned a solitary habit into a movement.³

What follows over the next two pages is the descent: the community and its factions, the gear ladder written for a buy-once buyer, the releases of the last year that actually moved the hobby, the law that governs every dig, and the honest reckoning – including the part where you mostly dig bottle caps, and the Thames permit you can no longer get.¹

The appeal is not the metal; it is the contact. A detectorist will tell you the pull is standing in a field where people have lived for two thousand years and pulling a Roman coin from the plough soil – a direct line to a hand that dropped it, unmediated by a museum case.¹ That is also why the hobby’s ethics run hot: every object is a small piece of a shared record, and how you treat it – recorded and returned to context, or pocketed and sold – is the whole moral argument of the pastime.³

~95%

OF BRITAIN’S ANNUALLY-RECORDED ARCHAEOLOGICAL FINDS COME FROM AMATEUR DETECTORISTS AND MUDLARKS – THE HOBBY IS, QUIETLY, THE COUNTRY’S LARGEST ARCHAEOLOGY PROGRAMME

THE CHATTER · THE GATHERING PLACES

The split is generational. Reddit’s r/metaldetecting is the fast, US-leaning hub of “what is this?” posts and first-find celebrations; the old-guard forums – Friendly Metal Detecting Forum, Steve Herschbach’s DetectorProspector, TreasureNet – hold the deep, brand-tribal technical knowledge. On YouTube, Aquachigger (river relics) and Nugget Noggin run past a million and three-quarters of a million subscribers; Nicola White’s “Tideline Art” is the mudlarking face at around 190,000.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE ARCHAEOLOGY TENSION

Archaeologists were long wary of detecting, and for cause: illegal “nighthawking” on protected or permission-less land damages the record irreparably. The honest settlement, since Britain’s recording scheme launched in 1997, is that responsible detectorists who log their finds are valued contributors while nighthawks are thieves – and that not everyone records.³

SOURCES 1 Portable Antiquities Scheme (finds.org.uk); Port of London Authority foreshore guidance. 2 reddapi.dev (subreddit sizes); Social Blade / vidIQ (YouTube subs); romanfound.substack.com (City of London finds). 3 Daily Telegraph via PressReader (*Detectorists* effect); laramaiklem.com; Trafficking Culture / Historic England (nighthawking).

THE DEEP END · THE MACHINE, BOUGHT ONCE

Skip the throwaway tier: the buy-once ladder runs from a three-hundred-dollar Nokta to a flagship you probably do not need

The community's own verdict is blunt — sub-hundred-and-fifty-dollar detectors find bottle caps and quitters. Buy a real machine, learn it, and resist the treadmill up to the thousand-five flagship.

Start where the community starts: not at the bottom. A cheap no-name detector is the classic false economy — falsing, no depth, a frustrated owner who either quits or buys twice. The entry-of-quality tier begins around three hundred and fifty dollars: the Nokta Score, with simultaneous multi-frequency at a value price, or the waterproof Simplex line; Garrett's new Vortex VX5 at about four hundred and fifty, uniquely software-upgradeable to the VX9; Minelab's Vanquish.¹ This is the "buy it and learn it" tier, and for many hobbyists it is also the last machine they need.

The middle is where serious hobbyists actually land, roughly five hundred to a thousand dollars: the Minelab Equinox 700 at about seven-fifty and the 900 at nine-ninety-nine, the darling of the class; the Nokta Legend, now the Legend 2, shipping from about a thousand as a two-coil package; Garrett's AT Pro and AT Max, the workhorse waterproof relic machines.¹ The high end — a thousand to eighteen hundred — is the "endgame all-terrain" tier: the Minelab Manticore at around fifteen hundred, and the fully-wireless XP Deus II at about fourteen-fifty, waterproof and firmware-forever.² Beyond that lies the specialist world — pulse-induction gold machines like the Minelab GPX 6000 at seven thousand, the new GPZ 8000 up to twelve, a subculture unto themselves.²

The accessories are where buy-once quietly pays. A Garrett Pro-Pointer AT pinpointer at about a hundred and twenty-eight dollars is near-universal; a Lesche digger at sixty is the standard blade; and for beach and water, the custom tier is real — titanium sand scoops from CKG and the cult Ukrainian maker Stavr, and aftermarket coils for depth or trashy ground.² The economics, honestly tiered: a curious

dabbler is in for about four hundred dollars, a committed hobbyist eleven-to-thirteen hundred, a serious endgame rig seventeen hundred to two thousand.¹

THE BUY-ONCE LADDER

Entry of quality — Nokta Score ~\$349 · Garrett Vortex VX5 ~\$449

Mid — Equinox 700/900 ~\$749–999 · Nokta Legend 2 ~\$999

High end — Manticore ~\$1,499 · XP Deus II ~\$1,449

Specialist gold — GPX 6000 ~\$6,999 · GPZ 8000 up to ~\$11,999

Meridian original — where the money goes, and where the community says to stop.

\$999 vs \$1,499

THE EQUINOX 900 AGAINST THE MANTICORE FLAGSHIP — THE COMMUNITY SAYS THE CHEAPER MACHINE FINDS THE SAME TARGETS FOR FIVE HUNDRED LESS ON ORDINARY GROUND

THE CHATTER · THE CUTTING EDGE

The most impactful all-terrain release of the year is the **Nokta Legend 2** (November 2025): a ground-up rework — new coil ecosystem, ninety-nine-point target IDs, a dedicated relic mode, longer battery, bone-conduction headphone support — that keeps Nokta's "flagship features at mid price" pressure on Minelab. At the top, the **Minelab GPZ 8000** (shipping March 2026, up to twelve thousand dollars) is a real tech step for elite gold prospectors and a price only they will pay.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE UPGRADE TREADMILL

You do not need the Manticore. The community's own honest line is that the Equinox 900 captures the same finds for five hundred dollars less on everyday ground; the flagship's edge — extra depth, a 2D target map for reading bottle caps against coins in iron-heavy dirt — matters only to experienced hunters on difficult sites. Buying the flagship first is the classic money pit.²

SOURCES 1 Serious Detecting, Kellyco, MetalDetector.com listings (via search index); usa.minelab.com (Equinox). 2 metaldetectingshop.com / detectorfinder.com (Manticore); myersdepot.com (Deus II); academy.com (Pro-Pointer AT); ckgcoop.com; detectorfinder.com (GPX). 3 detectorwarehouse.com (Legend 2, Nov 2025); DetectorProspector database (GPZ 8000, Mar 2026).

THE DEEP END • THE LAW, THE JARGON, AND THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Permission is the whole game — and the Thames permit is the one you can no longer get

Every dig needs a landowner's yes; treasure must be reported; and the romance of mudlarking collides with a waiting list ten thousand names deep. For a Singapore reader, this is largely a holiday hobby.

The law is not a footnote here; it is the hobby's spine. In England and Wales you need the landowner's permission always, and treasure must be reported — a 2023 reform widened the definition to cover nationally important base-metal finds, not only gold, silver and hoards.¹ Scotland is stricter still: under Treasure Trove, the Crown can claim any archaeologically significant portable find of any material, and not reporting is an offence.¹ The United States is a patchwork — legal on many public beaches, off-limits in state and national parks, permission on private land, always fill your holes.²

The mudlarking romance runs straight into a wall. A permit from the Port of London Authority is legally required to search the Thames foreshore at all; new applications were suspended in 2022 amid a demand surge, reopened in late 2024, and then — with the waiting list past ten thousand names — suspended again. For a newcomer in 2026 the scheme is effectively closed, and most permits are eyes-only: no digging, no detecting.² And for a Singapore reader the honest verdict is that this is a hobby you take on holiday: detecting here is a beach-only, fill-your-holes, low-yield affair, with parks and heritage land effectively out.²

Hammered — a hand-struck medieval coin, the British grail.

Target ID (TID) — the numeric conductivity readout; “a solid 78.”

Iron grunt — the low, broken growl of ferrous junk.

Coin spill — a cluster from one dropped purse.

Gridding — systematic overlapping-lane coverage of a site.

Nighthawking — illegal detecting without permission; the hobby's shame.

10,000+

NAMES ON THE SUSPENDED THAMES MUDLARKING WAITING LIST — THE INSTAGRAM VERSION OF THE HOBBY OVERSELLS AN ACCESS THAT NO LONGER EXISTS

THE CHATTER • THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

The honest starter path: lurk first — r/metaldetecting for reality-checks, DetectorProspector for depth, a local club for permissions. Then spend about six hundred to seven hundred dollars once: a Nokta Score or, if you can stretch, an Equinox 700; a Pro-Pointer AT; a Lesche digger; a finds pouch. Get one legal permission, learn the one machine's tones, dig everything at first to calibrate your ear, and always cut a clean plug and refill it.³

THE SCEPTIC • THE BOTTLE-CAP TRUTH

You will mostly dig trash — bottle caps, ring pulls, foil, nails. Good targets are the exception; even the YouTubers edit hours of junk out of every video. The upgrade treadmill and the “endgame is a myth” gripe are real, and the hobby's worst self-inflicted wound is the minority who detect without permission and make farmers and archaeologists distrust everyone.²

NEXT DESCENTS • YOU PICK THE NEXT HOBBY

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and the aging cave: a patient dairy craft with a real gear ladder.

RC rock crawlers — scale rigs built, tuned and driven over rocks; a deep parts economy and a trail-driving culture.

Model rocketry — Estes to high-power certification: launch clubs, altimeters, and a clear tier ladder into the sky.

SOURCES 1 NCMD (Treasure Act 2023 reform); Museums Galleries Scotland (Treasure Trove). 2 Port of London Authority foreshore permits (2022 suspension / 2024 reopening / re-suspension, via Yahoo News/Euronews); Serious Detecting (US laws); ClubsSNAP / enthusiast forums (Singapore reality, flagged for local by-law check). 3 r/metaldetecting; DetectorProspector; retailer listings (starter kit prices).

THE LONG GAME · THE STRENGTH SWEET SPOT

Ninety to a hundred and twenty minutes of lifting a week — and nothing extra to be had past it

A thirty-year, 147,000-person study puts a number on resistance training and death — and the number plateaus early. Pair it with a zone-2 base rather than choosing one. General guidance, not medical advice.

The British Journal of Sports Medicine published in June a study large enough to be worth reading twice: three long-running cohorts, 147,374 people, 35,798 deaths, up to thirty years of repeated measures.¹ The finding a mid-forties reader should take home: about ninety to a hundred and nineteen minutes a week of resistance training was associated with thirteen per cent lower all-cause mortality, nineteen per cent lower cardiovascular and twenty-seven per cent lower neurological-disease mortality — and no extra benefit beyond a hundred and twenty minutes a week.¹ The lowest mortality of all belonged to those combining aerobic work with strength, not choosing between them.¹

In practice that is two or three forty-minute lifting sessions, laid over a zone-2 aerobic base. More barbell time is not buying more years in this data — a genuinely useful ceiling for anyone who treats the gym as an optimisation problem.²

The bigger prize in the data is not strength alone but the pairing. The lowest mortality of the whole cohort belonged to people combining a solid aerobic dose with resistance training — roughly thirty to forty-five MET-hours a week of cardio alongside an hour or two of lifting — not to those who maxed out either one.¹ For a mid-forties reader the takeaway is to stop treating zone-two and the barbell as competing claims on the week and to run both: the aerobic base for the engine, the strength work for the independent signal the study isolates.²

THE PROTOCOL, PLAINLY

Strength: two or three forty-minute sessions — the sweet spot, with no bonus past it.¹

Aerobic: a zone-two base most weeks, with a little intensity to move VO2 max — the number that best predicts longevity.²

HR ~0.55

THE HAZARD RATIO FOR THE COMBINED HIGH-AEROBIC-PLUS-RESISTANCE GROUP — THE LOWEST OF THE STUDY, AND THE CASE FOR DOING BOTH

90–120 min

WEEKLY RESISTANCE TRAINING TIED TO THE MORTALITY BENEFIT — WITH THE CURVE FLAT BEYOND IT. THE SWEET SPOT IS LOWER THAN THE OPTIMISER ASSUMES

THE CHATTER · THE LONGEVITY READ

The discourse is mid-pivot — from “zone-2 is the magic bullet” to a soberer “zone-2 builds the base, intensity moves VO2 max, and strength carries its own independent mortality signal.” A Singapore GP’s widely-shared take makes the same point: do not fetishise one training zone.²

THE SCEPTIC

It is observational, so healthy-user bias is doing some work — people who lift for decades differ from those who do not, and the plateau past 120 minutes could be residual confounding rather than physiology. Adherence is the real limiter: most people never reach ninety minutes a week consistently. And the field’s credibility took a hit this year with the very public fall of its loudest VO2-max evangelist — a reminder to weigh the study, not the influencer.³

SOURCES 1 British Journal of Sports Medicine (online 2 Jun 2026; PubMed 42230125): Health Professionals Follow-up Study, Nurses’ Health Study I & II. 2 ScienceDaily; Fox News Health (plain-language write-ups); Dr Samuel Choudhury (Singapore GP, zone-2 commentary). 3 NBC News (longevity-influencer coverage, 2026). General guidance, not medical advice.

WHAT'S WORTH BOOKING · THE DATED AGENDA

A Grand Prix with its first Sprint, a snow slope counting down, and a sumo that goes on sale Saturday

The autumn calendar is loaded; the one to act on this week is Fukuoka's November basho, tickets on the nineteenth.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 30 SEP** ★ **Snow City — final day**
JURONG · THE INDOOR SNOW SLOPE CLOSURES FOR GOOD AFTER 26 YEARS · FAMILY, LAST CHANCE¹
- 2-3 OCT** **The Weeknd — After Hours Till Dawn**
NATIONAL STADIUM · GUEST CREEPY NUTS · ON SALE¹
- 9-11 OCT** ★ **F1 Singapore Grand Prix — first-ever Sprint**
MARINA BAY · SPRINT ADDED; THE KILLERS 10 OCT, LANA DEL REY 11 OCT · HAZE CONTINGENCY IN PLACE¹
- 17-18 OCT** **BIGBANG**
NATIONAL STADIUM · SECOND NIGHT ADDED · ON SALE²
- 10-11 NOV** **My Chemical Romance**
NATIONAL STADIUM · SOLD OUT²
- 25 NOV** **Guns N' Roses**
NATIONAL STADIUM · ON SALE²
- 28-29 NOV** **Babymonster**
INDOOR STADIUM · ON SALE²
- 19 SEP-22 NOV** **Deepavali light-up**
LITTLE INDIA · DEEPAVALI FALLS 8 NOV · FREE FAMILY EVENING¹
- 21-27 SEP** **Mid-Autumn Festival**
GARDENS BY THE BAY / CHINATOWN · LANTERNS · FREE FAMILY EVENING¹
- 22-24 JAN** **Art SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS · THE REGION'S BIGGEST FAIR RETURNS · PLAN AHEAD²
- 12 FEB** **Maroon 5**
NATIONAL STADIUM · 2027 DATE ON SALE²

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 8-22 NOV** ★ **Kyushu Basho — Grand Sumo**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · TICKETS ON SALE SAT 19 SEP VIA TICKET OOSUMO · WEEKENDS SELL OUT IN HOURS³
- 4-11 FEB** **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI PARK, HOKKAIDO · PLAN FLIGHTS NOW FOR FEB³
- 14 NOV** **Orsay masterpieces — Tokyo**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM · OPENS 14 NOV, ADVANCE TICKETS 28 SEP³
- 25 NOV-6 DEC** **Rikugien autumn illumination**
TOKYO · MAPLE MOMIJI LIT AFTER DARK³
- 13-18 APR** **Bruno Mars — Singapore 2027**
NATIONAL STADIUM · GENERAL SALE NOW OPEN FOR APRIL SHOWS²
- 16-17 JAN** **Westlife — The 25 Tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · 16 SOLD OUT, 17 ADDED²
- 14 NOV** **Marunouchi winter illuminations**
TOKYO · MID-NOV TO MID-FEB · THE WALKABLE LIGHT AVENUE³

SOURCES 1 SingaporeGP.sg; VisitSingapore; venue listings; events-ledger verification log to 14 Sep. 2 Ticketmaster SG / Live Nation SG; The Kallang; venue confirmations. 3 Ticket Oosumo (Kyushu Basho on-sale 19 Sep); sapporo.travel; tobikan.jp; japan-guide listings.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

A ten-seat yakitori counter the critics already crowned — and two openings too new to call

Toriei is the pick of the month; Noor and Sushidan are worth watching, honestly held until the reviews land.

The one to book is **Toriei**, a ten-seat, counter-only yakitori omakase from Chef Roy Koh — of the casual favourite Skewers — on the fourth floor of Cuppage Plaza.¹ At about a hundred and eighty dollars a head, the binchotan-grilled, chicken-centric menu runs a dozen skewers through the prized cuts — the bonjiri tail, the soriresu oyster — plus vegetables, a donabe rice course and dessert. Time Out Singapore has called it the best yakitori in the city right now; with only ten stools, booking is not optional.¹ This is the New-Peg Test passed cleanly: a genuine opening, genuinely reviewed, that earns the trip.

Two more are worth watching, and the honest verdict on both is that it is too early. **Noor**, in River Valley, is chef Titus Thamils' Mediterranean cooking with an understated Japanese influence — concept-strong, but essentially unreviewed at press time, so we hold it.² And **Sushidan** at Parkway Parade is the second Singapore outlet of a Michelin-pedigreed sushi group, bringing omakase to the east; anticipation is high on pedigree, but it is too new for a full verdict.² Saying so is the point: a soft-launch is not a review, and a pedigree is not a meal.

Two more names are worth a line for the diary-keeper, though they are moves rather than debuts and so fail the New-Peg Test as leads: Osteria Mozza has relocated to ION Orchard, and a second Bibim Deli — from a *Culinary Class Wars* alumnus — has opened at Jem. Neither is new cooking; both are new addresses, which is a booking note, not a review.²

10 seats

AT TORIEI'S COUNTER — THE CONSTRAINT THAT MAKES IT THE MONTH'S HARDEST RESERVATION AND ITS clearest RECOMMENDATION

THE CHATTER · THE BUZZ

The food-media read on Toriei is unusually unified — the Skewers pedigree plus a proper omakase format has the reviewers onside early. On the other openings, the socials are running on pedigree and photos rather than verdicts; treat the anticipation as anticipation, not a rating.¹

THE SCEPTIC

“Michelin-pedigreed” and “by the team behind” are the two phrases that most reliably outrun the food. A second outlet is not the first; a soft launch is a rehearsal. The tags below are what is confirmed — concept, neighbourhood, price band — not a promise about the plate.

~\$S180++

TORIEI'S OMAKASE — THE PRICE OF A TEN-SEAT, CHICKEN-THROUGH-BINCHOTAN COUNTER THE CRITICS RATED BEFORE THE CROWDS FOUND IT

YAKITORI OMAKASE

CUPPAGE PLAZA

~\$S180++

MEDITERRANEAN · RIVER VALLEY

SUSHI · PARKWAY PARADE

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

Post Malone (Singapore) remains off — the previously-listed date was pulled and no new date has been confirmed; it is not in this diary and stays off until a promoter or venue says otherwise.²

Too new to call, both. Noor and Sushidan open on concept and pedigree; neither has drawn a settled critical verdict yet, so we flag the anticipation as anticipation and will come back when the reviews land.²

The pick, in one line. If you book one counter this month, book Toriei — ten seats, binchotan, and the Skewers team doing the version they always wanted to.¹

THE UNDERCURRENT · MONGOLIA

Financial fast food: how Mongolia's app-loan boom quietly became a way to buy dinner

The world looks at Mongolia's copper and coal. It should look at the loan apps multiplying "like mushrooms after rain" — and at a pensioner whose entire pension now services a debt.

In Ulaanbaatar the fastest-growing financial product is not a mine share; it is an app. Mongolians call the instant digital loans *tsakhim zeel*, and one local outlet has a sharper name for them — the country's financial *türgen khool*, its "fast food": convenient, available in seconds, quietly corrosive, and spreading, in the phrase everyone uses, like mushrooms after rain.¹ The apps were sold as the good story — financial inclusion, leapfrogging, the unbanked brought into the system by impact investors and development finance. In 2026 that story has quietly inverted.¹

Start with the scale. Consumer loans across the banking system reached 11.4 trillion tugrik — about 3.2 billion dollars — at the end of 2024, up more than a third in a year, with pension loans alone contributing a fifth of that growth; household debt stood at 42.3 per cent of GDP by early 2025.² Non-bank credit, where the app lenders live, grew faster still — up nearly fifty-five per cent year-on-year, driven, the IMF notes, primarily by loans to individuals.² There are now over five hundred non-bank financial institutions, dozens of them digital lenders, in a country of roughly three and a half million people.³

Then the number that stops you. More than half of Mongolia's pension recipients hold pension loans, at an average debt-to-income ratio near eighty-four

per cent — and for 87.7 per cent of those pensioner-borrowers, roughly a quarter of a million people, income after repayment falls below the subsistence minimum. For 40,500 of them, the entire pension goes to servicing debt.³ A new rule now forces lenders to leave a subsistence floor after repayment — a regulator's admission of how close to the edge the lending had run.³

The mechanism is what makes it modern. A pension is a predictable state cash flow, which is exactly what an algorithm loves to lend against: fixed, verifiable, and easy to garnish at source. The apps did not invent Mongolian hardship; they made it borrowable in seconds, against a future the borrower cannot renegotiate.¹ The result is a country where more than half of pensioners carry a loan against their pension, and where the state's promise of old-age security has been quietly re-financed through a phone.³

The apps were sold as the good story — inclusion, leapfrogging, the unbanked brought in. In 2026 that story quietly inverted.

~250,000

PENSIONER-BORROWERS WHOSE INCOME AFTER LOAN REPAYMENT FALLS BELOW MONGOLIA'S SUBSISTENCE MINIMUM — INCLUSION TURNED INTO SUBSISTENCE

SOURCES 1 gogo.mn (the "financial fast food" framing, attributed as reported). 2 IMF 2025 Article IV (Country Report 25/265): household debt 42.3% of GDP, NBFI credit +54.7% y/y; Bank of Mongolia consumer-loan data via montsame.mn / thinkmongol.mn. 3 Bank of Mongolia / Financial Regulatory Commission via montsame.mn (pensioner distress; NBFI count); The Fintech Times (Mongolia 2026).

THE UNDERCURRENT · MONGOLIA · II

Why a resource-rich country borrows to eat — and why the regulator keeps ratcheting the caps

Food inflation running at double the headline rate, a currency down nearly half in a decade, and a state that itself subsidises more youth borrowing. The tell is not a crash; it is the quiet tightening.

The engine underneath is the cost of food. Mongolia imports its rice, sugar and cooking oil, about half its flour, and can grow fresh vegetables outdoors only a few months a year; the tugrik has lost close to half its value against the dollar over the past decade.¹ Food inflation has run around double the headline rate in early 2026, and a meat-price spike drove the general index sharply higher — figures that come via Mongolian-media summaries and are worth holding lightly, but that point one way.¹ When the staples outrun the paycheck, credit fills the gap, and the app makes the gap fillable in seconds.

The regulator has been quietly alarmed for two years. Online-loan products were capped at seventy per cent debt-to-income in 2023; the bank consumer-loan cap was cut to fifty per cent in March 2025; the non-bank cap sits at sixty — three tightenings in two years, which the IMF calls welcome while urging the non-bank limits be aligned with the banks'.² Non-bank consumer rates are capped at four and a half per cent a month — roughly fifty-four a year — and the informal lenders beyond them charge far more.² Meanwhile the 2026 state budget subsidises interest on a planned block of youth loans: the government itself is financing more borrowing even as it caps the rest.³

The irony sits in the funding. The flagship lender, backed by Japanese and global capital, raised up to twenty million dollars from an impact investor and

more from a development-markets fund — all of it branded “financial inclusion.”³ The money that was meant to bank the unbanked is now, at the margin, financing the grocery run.

None of this reads as a crisis yet, which is the point and the danger both. The banking system looks sound, the headline growth numbers are strong, and Mongolia’s copper and coal keep the current account respectable — so the world’s attention stays on the mines, not the loan book.¹ The signal is not a default wave; it is the regulator quietly cutting the caps three times in two years while insisting everything is fine. A supervisor who was relaxed would not keep tightening.²

When the staples outrun the paycheck, credit fills the gap — and the app makes the gap fillable in seconds.

~-45%

THE TUGRIK AGAINST THE DOLLAR OVER A DECADE — THE IMPORTED-FOOD MULTIPLIER THAT TURNS A CURRENCY SLIDE INTO A GROCERY-BILL CRISIS (FIGURE HELD, VIA MONGOLIAN-MEDIA SUMMARIES)

3× in 2 years

DEBT-TO-INCOME CAPS TIGHTENED BY MONGOLIA’S REGULATORS SINCE 2023 — THE QUIET TELL THAT THE “INCLUSION” BOOM HAD RUN TOO HOT

SOURCES 1 Asia News Network (meat-price inflation); TradingEconomics; mongoliaweekly.org / thinkmongol.mn (food-inflation and depreciation figures, via Mongolian-media summaries — held). 2 IMF 2025 Article IV; montsame.mn (DTI caps: 70% online 2023, 50% bank Mar 2025, 60% NBF). 3 lemonpress.mn / budget documents (youth-loan interest subsidy); Lendable / Developing World Markets (impact funding).

THE UNDERCURRENT · MONGOLIA · III

The company store, and the ordinance that came too late — what Mongolia's boom rhymes with

Andhra Pradesh in 2010 is the sharpest precedent: celebrated inclusion, app-driven over-lending, and an emergency clampdown. Mongolia is early on the same arc — which is exactly why it is worth watching now.

History offers two rhymes. The older one is the company store — wages that could not cover food, topped up by credit from the same system, binding people to a debt they could not out-earn. A currency down by half and a shelf stocked with imports is the modern version of owing your soul to the store.¹ The sharper rhyme is more recent: Andhra Pradesh, 2010, when impact-capital-backed microlenders — feted for inclusion, one of them freshly listed — outran their borrowers' capacity to repay, over-indebtedness spiralled, and the Indian state slammed on an emergency ordinance that nearly killed the sector overnight.¹

Mongolia is early on that same arc: celebrated inclusion, then app-driven over-lending, then a regulator reaching for the caps. India's 2010 ordinance is Mongolia's 2023–25 tightenings — the difference being that Mongolia is regulating before the blow-up rather than after it. That is the argument of this piece: when a society stops believing the wage or the state will provide, a financial product becomes emotional infrastructure, and “inclusion” can curdle into financialised subsistence — people borrowing not to build but to eat.²

The forecast worth making is narrow and testable. If food inflation stays ahead of wages and the tugrik keeps sliding, the subsistence-floor rule will not hold the line, and Mongolia will face its own version of India's 2010 reckoning — not a banking collapse, but a political one, when a quarter of a million pensioners with nothing left after repayment become a constituency.² The country regulated early, which is its best chance of writing a different ending than

Andhra Pradesh did. Whether early is early enough is the open question, and it will be answered in the grocery aisle, not the copper market.¹

India's 2010 ordinance is Mongolia's 2023–25 tightenings — the difference being that Mongolia is regulating before the blow-up rather than after it.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WOULD FALSIFY THIS

The IMF itself calls Mongolian household debt “still moderate” by cross-country standards, with a non-performing-loan ratio around five per cent — no systemic crisis yet. Much of the lending is genuinely productive: the flagship app reportedly serves informal micro-businesses, many women-owned. And “borrowing to eat” is an interpretation, not a measured statistic — it rests on correlation (surging consumer loans, surging food prices, sub-subsistence pensioners), not on a survey tracing loan proceeds to groceries. If borrowers' money were going mainly to durables and businesses, or incomes caught up to prices, the thesis collapses into an ordinary credit-deepening story.³

When a society stops believing the wage or the state will provide, a financial product becomes emotional infrastructure.

42.3%

HOUSEHOLD DEBT AS A SHARE OF GDP — “STILL MODERATE,” SAYS THE IMF, WHICH IS THE SCEPTIC'S STRONGEST CARD AND THE REASON TO WATCH, NOT PANIC

SOURCES 1 Historical: the truck-system / company-store literature; the 2010 Andhra Pradesh microfinance crisis and emergency ordinance (SKS Microfinance). 2 The essay's argument, built on the sourced figures at pp21–22. 3 IMF 2025 Article IV (household debt “moderate,” NPL ~5.2%); Lendable (micro-business lending); author's falsification test.

M E R I D I A N

THE LAST WORD

What you cannot buy your way out of

Mencken's clear, simple, wrong answer turned up in every room this week. A central bank raised the price of money against a shock money cannot fix, and gold made records to prove the lever does not reach the strait. A city met a smoke law that has never once worked and reached for masks and cooling rooms instead of writs. A country reclassified a drug and issued metal detectors to schools, then — on the same date — quietly opened a treatment door, because enforcement alone was the clear, simple, wrong answer. And in Ulaanbaatar the simplest fix of all, more credit, sold as inclusion, ended with a pensioner borrowing for rice. The buy-once desks answer from the far side and in the same key: the honest version of a thing — a glass with a pulled stem, a watch with an in-house movement, a boot you resole — charges its cost up front, because there is no cheaper way that also lasts. The lever that promises to move the world for nothing is always available. It is also, reliably, the one that does not reach the fire.

T W E L V E D E S K S · O N E W O R L D

SOURCES, THIS ISSUE — World/Macro: Bloomberg, CNBC, CNN, FDD, Al Jazeera, The National, Euronews, Arms Control Association, International Crisis Group, OilPrice, J.P. Morgan, Goldman Sachs, CME FedWatch, TradingEconomics, Chase, Robinhood. Singapore: Malay Mail, Tempo, Inquirer, MSE, AsiaOne, MAS, Enterprise Singapore, PMO, The Star, HardwareZone. Atelier: WebstaurantStore, GlasswareGuru, Zwiesel/IWA, CMOG, Harpers, Wine Spectator, Wine Berserkers, *Journal of Wine Research*, SevenFifty Daily, Wine Folly, Duralex. Technology: 24/7 Wall St., Tradingpedia, GuruFocus, CNBC, TechCrunch, Hugging Face, CFR, Tom's Hardware, 3DCenter, Artificial Analysis. Kit/Good Life: Bloomberg, Engadget, 9to5Mac, Into the HiFi; Fratello, MasterHorologer, Gear Patrol, Luxe Digital. Screen: film-book, Forbes, CBR, Rotten Tomatoes, CNN, Television Academy, Exclaim! Family/Fitness: CNB, MOH, HSA, *Singapore Medical Journal*, Malay Mail; *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, ScienceDaily, NBC News. Rabbit Hole: PAS, reddapi.dev, Social Blade, PressReader, NCMD, Museums Galleries Scotland, PLA, Serious Detecting, Kellyco, DetectorProspector, detectorwarehouse. Long Read: IMF Article IV 2025, Bank of Mongolia, montsame.mn, thinkmongol.mn, gogo.mn, The Fintech Times, Asia News Network, Lendable. Diary: SingaporeGP, Ticketmaster SG, Live Nation SG, Ticket Oosumo, Time Out SG, The Ranting Panda, Honeycombers. — No personal identifier appears in this edition; it is made to be shared.